

Delayed gratification

This means trying to keep short-term bursts of satisfaction in perspective, and sometimes choosing to forego them in order to achieve a bigger, longer-lasting sense of happiness later on. In the context of money, this might mean avoiding spending on frivolous things, or things that you don't see any long-term value in, in favour of experiencing a better sense of financial security long-term.

As we'll discuss later, our brains are biased towards the decision that will give us the most instant hit of satisfaction, even if there is a far greater win to be had in the future. Our brains prefer instant gratification, which is why it's so tempting to skip an exercise session in favour of Netflix even though we know we'll feel stronger and calmer later if we hit the gym. It's also why we might struggle to control the urge to snack when we know we have a lovely meal ahead of us shortly, or to make impulse purchases when what we really want is to save for a house deposit. The further away the gratification is, the more tempting the stopgap becomes, even when it's actively detrimental to our big goal.

In practising delayed gratification, we allow ourselves to enjoy the process of getting somewhere. We take the focus off the little, short-lived pings of pleasure and energy that we get from those instant gratifications, and start to enjoy steady progress and the journey as a whole.